

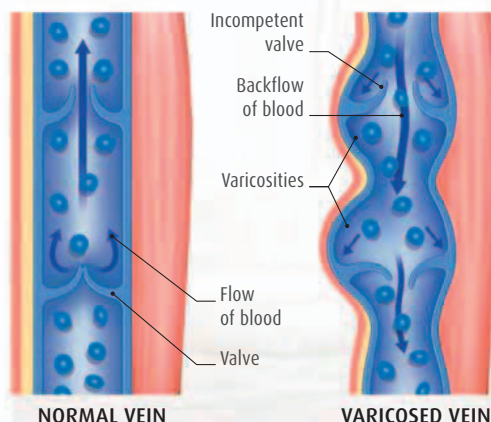
Q My mother had terrible varicose veins when she was pregnant. Will this happen to me?

Varicose veins are one of the most common side effects of pregnancy and they usually occur in the third trimester. If you do get them, your doctor can tell you how they can be treated after your baby is born.

A little under half of all pregnant women get varicose veins or hemorrhoids which are varicose veins in the anus (see p.132). You're more likely to suffer from them if a close member of your family has had them. They develop when progesterone levels in your body during pregnancy relax the walls of your blood vessels so they lose muscle tone. At the same time, your circulation is under greater strain from the increase in blood pumping around your body. Your veins are less taut and they also have more work to do. Aching in your legs is often the first sign that you might have varicose veins, as well as some itching around the affected veins.

If you think you might be at risk of varicose veins, your doctor can give you a compression hose, which helps to keep your veins "tightened." It is a good idea to exercise regularly and to avoid excessive weight gain, since this can exacerbate them.

Relieving the symptoms Lie down and raise your legs so that they are higher than your hips. Avoid standing for long periods.



How varicose veins form

Valves in the vein walls stop your blood from flowing back down your veins between pumps. During pregnancy, the valves, with only weakened vein walls to support them, can fail to work. Blood starts to pool, which makes the veins distended and swollen.



Q I had terrible acne as a teenager and now it's back. Why is pregnancy doing this?

When you were a teenager the surge of hormones during puberty caused your body to create excess sebum—the skin's natural lubricating oil. Now that you're pregnant, the same thing is happening again. Follow a strict cleansing routine for the skin on your face, morning and night, using a gentle, hypoallergenic cleanser. Avoid using a highly scented soap, which can dry out and irritate your skin. You can use an astringent if this has helped you in the past, but talk to your doctor before you do since many medicated astringents are not suitable for use during pregnancy.

Q What changes in my skin and nails should I expect?

You're likely to have a pregnancy glow from about the middle of your second trimester. It's partly because your blood volume increases, which means nutrients are carried more efficiently to all your organs, including your skin. Plumped-up cells—the result of increased fluid levels in your blood—can smooth out wrinkles and blemishes, while increases in the hormone progesterone can cause pinkness, making you look rosy. Hormone changes can make your body produce more sebum, which can give your skin a sheen. In addition to making you look radiant, hormones can make your skin very dry and possibly itchy. Some

women sweat more, which can cause rashes. Make sure you drink plenty of water to keep hydrated and use an unperfumed moisturizer. Nails can become harder, more brittle, or softer.

25%

Up to a quarter of women have **itchy or sensitive skin** during pregnancy. Keep some calamine lotion on hand to soothe general rashes.